3.3 Women's Rights and Seneca Falls

Like activists in modern civil rights movements, 19th-century activists in the women's rights movement felt an urgent sense of purpose. And when it came to establishing basic rights for women, failure was impossible.

MAIN IDEA In 1848, supporters of women's rights laid the groundwork for a movement that would change the lives of American women.

LEADERS FOR WOMEN'S RIGHTS

Throughout the early 1800s, women played active roles in social reform and abolition movements. Yet women continued to occupy a secondary place to men in society. When women earned wages outside of the home, their pay was much lower than the wages men received for doing the same job. Married women could not own or purchase property or enter into contracts. Single women had all the property rights a man had but were taxed on that property by a government in which they had no voice. Furthermore, because educational and career opportunities were so limited for women, marriage was often the only possible path to a financially stable life for most women.

The fight for women's rights had its roots in the abolition movement. Female abolitionists gained public speaking and organization experience, and some began to ask why women were not granted the same rights as men. **Elizabeth Cady Stanton** and **Lucretia Mott** were early leaders in the women's rights movement, and both were abolitionists.

Elizabeth Cady came from a wealthy family and received an excellent education at Troy Female Seminary. She married abolitionist Henry Brewster Stanton, became an abolitionist herself, and met many other abolitionists, including Lucretia Mott. Mott was a Quaker from Massachusetts who housed escapees traveling on the Underground Railroad.

In 1848, Mott and Stanton organized the **Seneca Falls Convention** in central New York. There, they issued a "Declaration of Sentiments and Resolutions." The Declaration of Sentiments framed the injustices faced by women in familiar language. As you know, the Declaration of Independence introduced the idea that all men are created equal. The Declaration of Sentiments inserted "and women" into that fundamental idea to reinforce the assertion that "all men and women are created equal." In this spirit, Stanton went a



Susan B. Anthony shows a document to Elizabeth Cady Stanton, seated, in 1900. In 1902, Anthony wrote to Stanton: "It is fifty-one years since we first met, and we have been busy through every one of them, stirring up the world to recognize the rights of women."

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AMERICAN PLACES

Women's Rights National Historical Park Seneca Falls, New York

The Women's Rights National Historical Park honors women who produced the Declaration of Sentiments. The statues featured here are the centerpiece of the park's visitors' center lobby. Notice Frederick Douglass standing with the women. Like many women's rights activists, he supported both abolition and women's rights.



step further and included women's **suffrage**, or the right to vote, in the Declaration of Sentiments. She knew opponents of women's suffrage would claim the demand was outrageous, and that it might hinder the acceptance of other ideas about women's rights. But because Stanton believed the right to vote was essential, she and Mott listed it as the first grievance in the Declaration of Sentiments.

CONTINUING THE WORK

In 1851, Sojourner Truth, who had attended Seneca Falls, delivered a powerful speech at the Women's Rights Convention in Ohio. She asked, "Ain't I a woman?" and drew attention to race in the fight for women's rights. Truth was a passionate supporter of equality for men and women of all races. That same year, Elizabeth Cady Stanton met **Susan B. Anthony**. Coming from a Quaker family, Anthony supported both temperance and abolition. The two women began a friendship and a political partnership that lasted more than 50 years. They traveled together, delivered speeches to lawmakers, planned campaigns, and published *The Revolution*, a newspaper devoted to women's rights.

During the 1850s and 1860s, issues regarding women's rights became less pressing because of the impending Civil War. However, after the war was over, women's rights activists picked up the cause again. In 1869, Anthony and Stanton founded the **National Woman Suffrage Association**, the first national women's rights organization. Anthony believed that the best way to bring attention to women's suffrage was to violate the law—by voting. When she tried to vote in the 1872 election, she was arrested and fined. Anthony never paid the fine and never went to jail.

The campaign for women's rights began in the early 1800s and continued through the rest of the 19th century and into the 20th. Some leaders worked until the day they died. Mott, Stanton, Truth, Anthony, and many other women's rights activists dedicated their lives to securing political and social equality for women.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the Seneca Falls Convention, and why was it significant?
2. **MAKE CONNECTIONS** In what ways were the movements for abolition and women's rights intertwined?
3. **SYNTHESIZE** How did women's rights activists link women's rights to the Founding Fathers' positions on equality and natural rights?

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